

PAN-SOUTH INDIAN

Thayir Sadam

Cooling Yogurt Rice

The Gentle Final Course of Every South Indian Meal

AUTHENTIC RECIPE · STEP-BY-STEP GUIDE · PRINTABLE DIGITAL COOKBOOK

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Thayir Sadam

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Contact: support@dhaniodigital.com

ABOUT THIS BOOK

Thayir Sadam

AUTHOR

Sweta Verma

PUBLISHER

DhanioDigital

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Nutrition values are estimates. Cooking times vary with equipment and ingredients. Readers with allergies or dietary restrictions should check every ingredient label before cooking.

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THE STORY BEHIND THE DISH

The Meal's Quiet, Essential Ending

In the traditional structure of a South Indian meal, curd rice — thayir sadam in Tamil, mosaru anna in Kannada — plays a specific and essential role: it's the final course, eaten after the more intensely flavored sambar and rasam rice courses, meant to cool the palate and settle the stomach. Its mild, creamy simplicity isn't a lack of ambition; it's precisely the point, a deliberate contrast to everything that came before it.

Ayurvedic food tradition, which continues to shape South Indian eating patterns, considers yogurt cooling and easily digestible, making curd rice a natural closing note for a meal, and also a common choice when someone is unwell, traveling, or simply wants something gentle and undemanding. Its simplicity has made it a genuine comfort food across generations, the dish South Indians often name when asked what they crave when feeling homesick or under the weather.

Curd rice also travels exceptionally well and requires no reheating, making it a favorite for lunchboxes and long journeys, and its garnish — often pomegranate seeds, grapes, or simply a tempering of mustard seeds and curry leaves — offers just enough variation to keep a fundamentally simple dish interesting across a lifetime of eating it.

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THE STORY BEHIND THE DISH

The Meal's Quiet, Essential Ending, continued

CULTURAL NOTES & OCCASIONS

Traditionally the final course of a South Indian meal, following sambar rice and rasam rice, meant to cool the palate and aid digestion. Considered cooling and easily digestible in Ayurvedic food tradition, making it a common choice for those feeling unwell or needing gentle food. Widely cited by South Indians as a nostalgic comfort food, often craved specifically when homesick or traveling. Requires no reheating and travels well, making it a favorite for lunchboxes and journeys.

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AT A GLANCE

Equipment & preparation

10m	10m	4	Easy
ACTIVE PREP	COOK TIME	SERVINGS	DIFFICULTY

Recommended equipment

- Mixing bowl
- Small pan, for the tempering
- Fork or spoon, for mashing the rice

STORAGE & MAKE-AHEAD

Curd rice keeps refrigerated for up to 2 days, though it thickens as it sits — thin with a splash of milk before serving if needed. It's not typically reheated, as it's traditionally served at room temperature or lightly chilled.

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WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Ingredients

For the dish

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Rice, cooked soft (slightly overcooked is fine)	2 cups	350 g cooked	2 katori
Plain yogurt	1½ cups	360 g	1½ katori
Milk	½ cup	120 ml	½ katori
Salt	¾ tsp	4.5 g	to taste

For the tempering & garnish

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Oil or ghee	1 tbsp	15 ml	1 chammach
Mustard seeds	½ tsp	2 g	½ chammach
Urad dal	1 tsp	3 g	1 chammach
Dried red chili	1	1	1
Curry leaves	1 sprig	8–10 leaves	1 sprig
Ginger, minced — optional	1 tsp	5 g	1 chammach
Fresh coriander, chopped	2 tbsp	8 g	2 tbsp
Pomegranate seeds, for garnish — optional	3 tbsp	40 g	3 chammach

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WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Ingredients, continued

SUBSTITUTIONS & SOURCING

This dish uses only common pantry staples and is one of the most accessible recipes to make anywhere in the world. Slightly overcooked, softer rice is actually preferred for curd rice, unlike most other rice dishes — don't worry about achieving perfectly separate grains here. Full-fat plain yogurt gives the creamiest, most traditional result.

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STEP BY STEP · STEP-BY-STEP

Making Curd Rice

01 MASH THE RICE SLIGHTLY

Using a fork or the back of a spoon, lightly mash the cooked rice — you want to break it down slightly, not to a smooth paste, but enough that it will absorb the yogurt evenly.

02 MIX IN THE YOGURT AND MILK

Add the yogurt and milk to the rice, mixing thoroughly until you reach a creamy, slightly loose consistency. Add salt and mix again.



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STEP BY STEP · STEP-BY-STEP

Making Curd Rice, continued

Chef tip. the milk isn't traditional in every household, but it helps keep the dish creamy and prevents it from thickening too much as it sits.

03 MAKE THE TEMPERING

Heat oil or ghee in a small pan, add mustard seeds, letting them pop, then urad dal, dried red chili, and curry leaves, frying until the dal turns golden.

04 ADD GINGER IF USING

Add the minced ginger to the tempering, cooking briefly until fragrant.

05 COMBINE AND GARNISH

Pour the tempering over the curd rice and mix gently. Garnish with fresh coriander and pomegranate seeds if using.

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STEP BY STEP · STEP-BY-STEP

Making Curd Rice, continued



Texture indicator. curd rice should be creamy and loose, almost like a thick porridge, not firm or dry like regular cooked rice.

MISTAKE TO AVOID

Using perfectly separate, firm rice grains, as you might for other rice dishes, results in a less authentic texture. Slightly softer, even overcooked rice is actually preferred here, as it blends more smoothly with the yogurt.

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SERVING & PAIRING

How to serve



Traditional Style

- Served as the final course of a South Indian meal, after sambar rice and rasam rice.
- Eaten on its own as a light, cooling meal when feeling unwell or during very hot weather.

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How to serve, continued

Family Style

- A comforting end to a family meal, often the dish children specifically request.

Modern Pairing

- Works well packed for lunch or travel, needing no reheating and staying fresh at room temperature.

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RESTAURANT-GRADE TRICKS

Chef secrets

Getting the Texture Right

- Lightly mashing the rice before adding yogurt helps it absorb evenly, avoiding a dish with dry, separate grains floating in liquid yogurt.
- A splash of milk keeps curd rice creamy over time, since yogurt alone can thicken considerably as the dish sits.

Make-Ahead & Meal Prep

- Curd rice actually benefits from a short rest before serving, letting the rice fully absorb the yogurt's flavor.
- Keep the tempering separate and add it fresh just before serving for the best aroma, if preparing rice and yogurt ahead of time.

RESTAURANT TRICK

Some South Indian restaurants add a small amount of grated cucumber or carrot for extra freshness and crunch, a modern touch on the traditional simple preparation.

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BONUS CONTENT

Nutrition, variations & FAQ

APPROXIMATE NUTRITION, PER SERVING

210 kcal	7 g	32 g	5 g	1 g
CALORIES	PROTEIN	CARBOHYDRATES	FAT	FIBER

Estimates only; actual values vary with oil and portion size.

ALLERGEN GUIDE

Contains, based on the ingredient list: Dairy, Mustard. Check packaged spices and asafoetida, which may contain wheat, and verify against your own ingredients.

REGIONAL VARIATIONS

Thayir Sadam	the classic Tamil Nadu style and name for this dish.
Mosaru Anna	the Karnataka name and style, sometimes with slightly different tempering spices.
Curd Rice with Grapes	some households add a few seedless grapes for a subtle sweetness alongside the pomegranate.

Why is my curd rice too thick?

It thickens as it sits — thin it out with a splash of milk or plain yogurt before serving.

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BONUS CONTENT

Nutrition, variations & FAQ, continued

Can I make this vegan?

Yes — use a plant-based yogurt and milk alternative; the texture and flavor will differ somewhat but remain enjoyable.

Is curd rice served hot or cold?

Traditionally at room temperature or lightly chilled, never hot — it's meant to be cooling, which is central to its purpose in a meal.

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REFERENCE

Ingredient glossary



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REFERENCE

Ingredient glossary, continued

GLOSSARY

Thayir Sadam	the Tamil name for curd rice, meaning "yogurt rice."
Mosaru Anna	the Kannada name for the same dish.
Prasadam	food offered to deities in Hindu temples; curd rice is a common offering.
Tadka	a tempering of spices bloomed in hot oil, finishing this dish.

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PRINTABLE RECIPE CARD

Thayir Sadam

10m	10m
ACTIVE PREP	COOK TIME
4	Easy
SERVINGS	DIFFICULTY

DISH

Rice	350 g cooked
Plain yogurt	360 g
Milk	120 ml
Salt	4.5 g

TEMPERING & GARNISH

Oil or ghee	15 ml
Mustard seeds	2 g
Urad dal	3 g
Dried red chili	1
Curry leaves	8–10 leaves
Ginger	5 g
Fresh coriander	8 g
Pomegranate seeds	40 g

METHOD

01 **Mash the rice slightly.** Using a fork or the back of a spoon, lightly mash the cooked rice — you want to break it down slightly, not to a smooth paste, but enough that it will absorb the yogurt evenly.

02 **Mix in the yogurt and milk.** Add the yogurt and milk to the rice, mixing thoroughly until you reach a creamy, slightly loose consistency.

03 **Make the tempering.** Heat oil or ghee in a small pan, add mustard seeds, letting them pop, then urad dal, dried red chili, and curry leaves, frying until the dal turns golden.

04 **Add ginger if using.** Add the minced ginger to the tempering, cooking briefly until fragrant.

05 **Combine and garnish.** Pour the tempering over the curd rice and mix gently.

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BEFORE YOU SHOP

Shopping list

☐ Rice	350 g cooked	☐ Plain yogurt	360 g
☐ Milk	120 ml	☐ Salt	4.5 g
☐ Oil or ghee	15 ml	☐ Mustard seeds	2 g
☐ Urad dal	3 g	☐ Dried red chili	1
☐ Curry leaves	8–10 leaves	☐ Ginger	5 g
☐ Fresh coriander	8 g	☐ Pomegranate seeds	40 g

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